Plan 2 · Offbeat Shimla + Manali (toy train)

Toy train to Shimla, then quiet valleys only: Mashobra, Shali Tibba, Narkanda–Hatu, Thanedar–Kotgarh, Jibhi, Chehni Kothi, Shoja, Jalori/Serolsar, Tirthan, Naggar, Jana, Sethan (NYE). 6 people · one Innova · Airbnb/homestays

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → Delhi day → Kalka Mail → **toy train** → Shimla (lunch) → Mashobra 1N → Narkanda 2N → Jibhi 2N → Tirthan (day) → Naggar → Sethan 1N (NYE) → Manali → bus → Delhi → Hyderabad
Why offbeat	You sleep in villages, not Mall Road hotels, and NYE is in a snow village instead of jammed Old Manali. Shimla's Ridge, Hadimba and Vashisht are still covered.
Snow chances	High: Hatu, Jalori/Serolsar, Sethan, Shali Tibba top. Medium: Narkanda, Shoja. Low–medium: Jibhi, Tirthan
Crowd level	Low almost everywhere
Difficulty	Easy–moderate. Optional snow hikes: Shali Tibba (3 km up), Hatu (if the road is shut), Serolsar (5 km each way)
Budget per person (6 people)	**≈ ₹22.5k shoestring · ≈ ₹29.9k recommended**
Temperatures	Narkanda −6 to 6 °C · Jibhi −2 to 10 °C · Sethan −10 to 2 °C

The one road to watch: Jalori Pass (3,120 m)

Jalori (Narkanda → Luhri → Ani → Jalori → Shoja → Jibhi, ~110 km, 5 h) usually closes after heavy snow from **mid to late December** and reopens in March–April.

Decide on 28 Dec evening (ask your Narkanda host / Ani police). Open → via Jalori. Closed → Narkanda → Shimla bypass → Sundernagar → Mandi → Aut → Banjar → Jibhi (~260 km, 8–9 h; ≈ ₹2,000 extra on the Innova). Jibhi itself is open year-round via Aut; you can still hike to Jalori / Serolsar from Shoja.

Getting there and back

Hyderabad → Delhi on 24 Dec: board in Hyderabad, Kazipet, Warangal or Vijayawada

Train	Where you board (time)	Reaches Delhi	Runs	Fare / person (SL · 3A)	Use it for
12723 Telangana SF Exp	**Hyderabad Deccan 06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25 · Kazipet 08:03/08:05	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Default.** Cheapest, boards in the city. Delhi day + night train/bus onward
12621 Tamil Nadu SF Exp	Vijayawada 03:50–04:05 · Warangal 06:50/06:52 · **Kazipet 06:55**	New Delhi **06:30** (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950 (from Kazipet)	**Fast option.** Catches the 07:40 Kalka Shatabdi → Shimla same evening
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad 07:00/07:10 · Kazipet ~08:50	H. Nizamuddin 05:30	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 (meals incl.)	Fast and comfortable but ~2× the 3A fare
12625 Kerala SF Exp	Vijayawada ~10:10–10:55 · Warangal ~13:30 · **Kazipet 13:45**	New Delhi 13:30	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950	Backup if 12723 is full (leave Hyderabad by 09:30 by bus)

Getting to Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada with 6 people: Kazipet and Warangal are ~140 km (2.5–3 h). TGSRTC buses run through the night from JBS/Uppal to Hanamkonda (≈ ₹200–300), or an Innova one-way ≈ ₹4,000–5,000 (≈ ₹750 pp). Vijayawada is ~275 km (5–6 h). Only worth it if Hyderabad quota is full, because you'd need an overnight bus on 23 Dec.

12723 halts in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior → Agra Cantt → New Delhi (~18 halts, ~1,680 km). Confirmed: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30.

Waitlisted? Check every station and halt this way

1. Direct pairs. On IRCTC / ConfirmTkt / ixigo, search 24 Dec: HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, **KZJ→NDLS, WL→NDLS, BZA→NDLS** (Kazipet, Warangal and Vijayawada have their own quotas). Note AVAILABLE / RAC / WL for every train above.

2. Every halt. If HYB→Delhi is WL, search the same train from HYB to each later halt (Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur). A shorter ticket can be AVAILABLE when the full one is WL. Ride to Agra, then any Agra→Delhi train or bus (2–3.5 h).

3. Book from the origin. For trains starting elsewhere (22691 from Bengaluru, 12621 from Chennai, 12625 from Thiruvananthapuram), search origin→Delhi and set **Boarding Point** = Secunderabad / Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada. You pay the full-route fare but get the origin's quota.

4. Split it. HYB→Nagpur + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains a day). Keep 2–3 h between them.

5. Tatkal on 23 Dec (AC 10:00, SL 11:00), 2 PNRs of 3 people each. Premium Tatkal costs more but confirms more often.

6. Tick Vikalp + auto-upgrade and only hold WL if it is under ~WL 20 (3A) / WL 40 (SL) this far out.

6 people = 1 PNR in general quota (max 6 passengers per ticket), but **Tatkal allows only 4 per PNR**, so Tatkal needs 2 bookings from 2 Aadhaar-verified IRCTC accounts at the same minute. Senior citizens get lower berths only in general quota.

Delhi → Kalka → Shimla by toy train (connections and buffers)

If you arrive in Delhi on…	Delhi → Kalka	Kalka → Shimla (toy train)	In Shimla	Buffers	Train cost / person
12723 Telangana · New Delhi ~07:40 (25 Dec)	**12311 Netaji (Kalka Mail)**, Old Delhi ~21:10 → Kalka ~03:00–04:40 (SL)	**52453 Kalka–Shimla Exp** ~06:00–06:20 (2S ≈ ₹65) or 52451 Shivalik Deluxe ~05:20–05:45 (CC ≈ ₹510)	~10:30–11:50 on 26 Dec	~13 h in Delhi = a sightseeing day; 1–3 h in Kalka waiting room	**≈ ₹265** (SL ≈ ₹200 + 2S ₹65)
12621 Tamil Nadu · New Delhi 06:30	**12011 Kalka Shatabdi**, New Delhi 07:40 → Kalka 11:40–11:45 (CC ≈ ₹885 incl. meal)	**52455 Himalayan Queen** 11:55–12:10 → ~17:20 (CC ≈ ₹265; 2S cheaper)	~17:20 on **25 Dec**	70 min at New Delhi (fog risk), ~25 min at Kalka (timed connection)	≈ ₹1,150
22691 Rajdhani · Nizamuddin 05:30	Same 12011 Shatabdi (Nizamuddin → New Delhi 15–20 min by metro/cab)	52455 Himalayan Queen	~17:20 on 25 Dec	~2 h at Delhi	≈ ₹1,150
12625 Kerala · New Delhi 13:30	12311 Kalka Mail ~21:10 (or 12005 Kalka Shatabdi 17:15 → 21:15 + a night in Kalka)	52453 / 52451 next morning	~11:00 on 26 Dec	~7.5 h Delhi	≈ ₹265

Late-December fog regularly delays trains from the south by 1–4 h. If the fast option misses the 07:40 Shatabdi, fall back to the Kalka Mail at night: you lose half a day, not the trip. Book the Shatabdi only after checking the Tamil Nadu Express running status the evening before (Tatkal opens 10:00 on 24 Dec).

Kalka–Shimla toy train timetable

Direction	Train	Departs	Arrives	Classes & approx fare	Notes
Kalka → Shimla	52457 Kalka–Shimla (earliest)	~03:30	~08:55	2S / FC	Listed by some 2026 guides. Verify; may be seasonal
Kalka → Shimla	72451 Rail Motor Car	05:10–05:25	~09:30	≈ ₹320	Glass-roof railcar, 14–18 seats; runs only with enough bookings
Kalka → Shimla	52451 Shivalik Deluxe	05:20–05:45	~10:05–10:40	CC ≈ ₹510 (breakfast incl.)	Fastest regular train
Kalka → Shimla	**52453 Kalka-Shimla Exp**	06:00–06:20	~11:05–11:50	**2S ≈ ₹65**; FC higher	Cheapest reserved seat
Kalka → Shimla	52455 Himalayan Queen	11:55–12:10	~17:20	2S cheap · CC ≈ ₹265 · FC ≈ ₹475	Connects with the 12011 Shatabdi

Timings differ by 10–25 min between sources (travelcoffee 2026, Shimla Tourism, exploreindia, totaltraininfo). Confirm on IRCTC/NTES when you book. Book toy-train seats on IRCTC as soon as the main train is confirmed; 25–26 Dec sells out. Sit on the right side going up for the valley views. The Him Darshan Vistadome (≈ ₹630) runs on some dates.

Back to Hyderabad by 3 Jan

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Fare (SL · 3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈ 20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr next day	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100	Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹780 · ≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00

Getting around as 6

Option for 6 people	Seats / luggage	Typical hill rate (2025-26)	Per person per day (÷6)	When to choose
Innova Crysta with driver	6–7 + roof carrier	₹4,000–5,500/day (min ~250 km) or ₹16–18/km, + tolls, parking, ₹300–500 driver night	≈ ₹750–1,000	Default for 6 with soft bags
Tempo Traveller 12-seater	Lots of room	₹4,500–7,500/day or ₹18–22/km	≈ ₹850–1,250	Heavy luggage; not allowed on some narrow roads / union areas
2 × Dzire / Etios	4 + 4	₹2,800–3,500/day each	≈ ₹950–1,150	Only if no SUV is available
Local taxi unions (Manali, Pahalgam, Gangtok, Joshimath)	Innova / Tavera / Sumo	Fixed rate cards per circuit	Varies	Mandatory for some circuits (Solang–Sissu, Aru–Betaab, Tsomgo)
Government bus (HRTC / JKSRTC / UTC)	Seats	₹1.5–3 per km	Cheapest	Long point-to-point legs (Shimla→Manali, Delhi→hills)

Book **one Innova Crysta with the same driver from 27 Dec to 1 Jan** (pickup Mashobra, drop Manali). A fixed per-day rate (≈ ₹4,500–5,500 + ₹400 driver night + tolls/parking) is cheaper than separate point-to-point taxis and keeps the luggage in one place.

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → on the train

• **06:00 12723 Telangana Express** (Secunderabad 06:25, Kazipet 08:05).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Delhi sightseeing day → 21:10 Kalka Mail

• Bags at the Old Delhi cloak room → Red Fort → Jama Masjid → Chandni Chowk → India Gate → Agrasen ki Baoli → CP → Sacred Heart (Christmas).

• Board **12311 Kalka Mail ~21:10** from Old Delhi (SL).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹700 Delhi + ₹200 train

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Toy train to Shimla → Mashobra

• Kalka ~03:00–04:40 → **52451 Shivalik Deluxe** (05:20–05:45) or **52453 Express** (06:00–06:20, 2S ≈ ₹65) → Shimla ~10:30–11:50.

• Quick Ridge + Christ Church + lunch on Mall Road → taxi to **Mashobra** (12 km) → sunset at **Naldehra** deodar meadow.

Stay: Airbnb Mashobra | **Day spend (per person):** ₹65–510 toy train + ₹250 taxi + ₹700 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Shali Tibba trek → Narkanda

• Innova starts. Drive to Khatnol, then **Shali Tibba (2,872 m)**: 3 km up to the Bhima Kali summit temple, the best panorama near Shimla. 3–4 h return; spikes help in snow.

• Drive to **Narkanda** via Fagu–Theog (~2 h).

Stay: Airbnb Narkanda | **Day spend (per person):** ₹930 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Hatu Peak · Tani Jubbar · Thanedar–Kotgarh

• Sunrise at **Hatu Peak (3,400 m)**: Hatu Mata temple (7 km snow walk if the road is shut). **Tani Jubbar lake**.

• **Thanedar & Kotgarh**: Stokes' apple orchards, 1843 St Mary's Church, Sutlej views. Evening: decide the Jalori route.

Stay: Airbnb Narkanda | **Day spend (per person):** ₹930 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Narkanda → Jibhi

• Route A (Jalori open): Luhri → Ani → **Jalori Pass** dhabas in snow → Shoja → Jibhi. Route B (closed): via Mandi–Aut, leave by 07:00.

• Evening: Jibhi village walk, riverside café.

Stay: Airbnb Jibhi | **Day spend (per person):** ₹930–1,250 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Chehni Kothi · Jibhi waterfall · Shoja · Serolsar

• **Chehni Kothi** tower temple (2 km walk up). **Jibhi waterfall** and the 'Mini Thailand' pool.

• **Shoja** (2,700 m) → if Jalori is open, hike 5 km to **Serolsar lake** with a local guide (₹1,500–2,000 per group); if closed, hike from Shoja as far as it's safe. Cafés close by ~21:00.

Stay: Airbnb Jibhi | **Day spend (per person):** ₹930 Innova share + ₹300 guide share + ₹700 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Tirthan morning → Naggar → Jana → Sethan (NYE in snow)

• Early to **Gushaini (Tirthan)**: river walk towards Bandal, trout farms at Nagini, GHNP (UNESCO) gate.

• Aut tunnel → Kullu → **Naggar Castle** + **Roerich gallery** → lunch at **Jana waterfall** → up to **Sethan (2,700 m)**.

• NYE bonfire away from the Manali crowd. Upgrade option: one igloo night (₹4,500–7,500 pp with meals).

Stay: Sethan / Prini homestay or chalet | **Day spend (per person):** ₹930 Innova share + ₹900 food/NYE

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Sethan snow → Vashisht → Old Manali → bus to Delhi

• Morning snow walk on the Hampta trail head. Down to Manali: **Hadimba temple**, **Vashisht hot springs**, Old Manali lunch. Innova drop.

• Evening bus to Delhi (16:00–18:00).

Stay: Overnight bus | **Day spend (per person):** ₹930 Innova share + ₹1,000–1,800 bus + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Delhi → train home

• Humayun's Tomb / Lodhi Garden → **16:00 12724 Telangana Express**.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹400 Delhi + ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

• Hyderabad ~17:10.

Where you sleep: Airbnb picks for 6 (best-rated and budget)

Nights	Area	Best-rated pick	Budget pick	Est. Dec price, 6 people / night	≈ per person / night
1 (26 Dec)	Mashobra	**Private Sunset Lawn 3BHK family cottage**: 4.94★ (17)	**Shimla View Homestay, Mashobra** (rooms)	₹5,000–8,000	₹850–1,350
2 (27–28 Dec)	Narkanda	**Hatu Peak View 3BR Villa | Homeyhuts**: 4.8★ (10). Splurge: Villa Vistas (5.0★, 6 reviews)	**Wild Orchard Pure Veg Homestay** or **Pahadi House** B&B (3 rooms)	₹5,000–8,000	₹850–1,350
2 (29–30 Dec)	Jibhi	**Jalori View Log House, Jibhi**: 4.97★ (74); or a Jibhi treehouse at 4.91★ (209) split across 2 units	Two-cottage riverside place in Tirthan (6 guests) · **Bini cottage** (2 cottages, 6) · **Hikers wooden cottage**	₹5,000–8,000	₹850–1,350
1 (31 Dec)	Sethan / Prini	**Woodland Chalet, Sethan** (5.0★, new, 3 reviews), or an igloo night	**Private rooms in Hamta village, Prini**: 4.85★ (133); book 3 rooms	₹6,000–9,000	₹1,000–1,500

Listing names, ratings and review counts come from Airbnb search results in Nov 2026. Airbnb blocks automated price checks, so the 'Dec price for 6' column is an **estimate** for an entire 3-bedroom place over the holiday week. Check the live total for your dates.

How to pick the best-rated vs the cheapest on Airbnb

Filters: Guests = 6 · Type of place = **Entire home** · Bedrooms ≥ 3 (or 2 + sofa-beds) · tick **Guest favourite** · toggle **'Display total before taxes'** so the price includes cleaning and service fees.

Best-rated vs cheapest: sort by price after setting the filters, then pick the cheapest listing with ≥ 4.7★ and ≥ 20 reviews. A 5.0★ with 3 reviews is not more reliable than a 4.8★ with 150.

Winter questions to message the host before booking: room heaters (some charge ₹300–500/night per heater), geyser/hot water, power backup, whether a car reaches the door (Old Manali, Vashisht, Jibhi and McLeodganj often have steep stairs), and snow-time access.

NYE rules: many hosts set a 2–3 night minimum for 30 Dec–1 Jan. Book those nights first with flexible or moderate cancellation.

Where Airbnb is thin (Zuluk, Aritar, Rinchenpong, Sari/Chopta, Sangla/Kalpa, Bandipur, Spiti), book homestays by phone or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip. Usually 3 rooms × ₹1,500–3,000 with meals.

Offbeat places in this plan

Place	Altitude	What's special	Snow late Dec	Crowd
Kalka–Shimla toy train	656 → 2,076 m	UNESCO hill railway	—	Medium
Mashobra / Naldehra	2,150 m	Orchard ridge, deodar meadow	Low–medium	Low
Shali Tibba	2,872 m	Summit temple trek	Medium–high	Very low
Narkanda + Hatu, Tani Jubbar	2,708 / 3,400 m	Snow slopes, wooden temple, lake	High	Low
Thanedar–Kotgarh	~2,000 m	Where Himachal's apples began; 1843 church	Low	Very low
Jalori + Serolsar lake	3,120 m	Snow pass, sacred forest lake	Very high (road may shut)	Very low
Jibhi, Chehni Kothi, Shoja	1,900–2,700 m	Wooden villages, tower temple	Medium	Low
Tirthan / Gushaini	1,600 m	Trout river, GHNP edge	Low–medium	Very low
Naggar, Jana, Sethan	1,800–2,700 m	Old capital, village food, igloo village	Sethan high	Low

Bike / scooty rentals

Where	Rates	Notes
Jibhi / Banjar	Scooty ₹700–1,000 (few shops; ask your host)	Fine for Jibhi–Chehni–Shoja on dry roads. Not on Jalori in snow
Manali	Scooty ₹500–800 · RE ₹1,200–2,500	Day 9 only if time allows. Sethan road is steep and icy, so use the Innova

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Gear budget: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 rentals on the trip. Plan budgets include only the rentals. Six people can share: buy 2 pairs of microspikes and 1 first-aid kit for the group instead of 6.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (−5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you won't reuse it: 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	Snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot
Gumboots / snow boots	Snow points	—	₹100–200/day (bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Treks	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Snow	₹300–800	—	Prevents snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Treks / icy walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri/Dharamkot ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Narkanda ski shops / HPTDC	Ski kit, gumboots, snow suits (when slopes are open)	₹300–500 suit; ski kit ₹700–1,000
Shoja / Jibhi homestays	Gumboots, sometimes microspikes and poles	₹100–250
Sethan igloo operators	Snow suits, boots, skis / snowboards	₹300–600
Indiahikes rentals (online)	Padded jacket, trek shoes, microspikes	₹55–150/day

Budget per person (6 people sharing)

Item (per person, 6 sharing)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Train Hyderabad → Delhi (12723)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Delhi day (metro, cloak room, entries)	₹400	₹500	
12311 Kalka Mail, Old Delhi → Kalka	₹200	₹200	SL (short overnight run; 3A ≈ +₹400)
Toy train Kalka → Shimla	₹65	₹65	52453 2S (Shivalik Deluxe CC ≈ ₹510 if you prefer)
Shimla → Mashobra taxi + Naldehra	₹250	₹250	₹1,500 ÷ 6
One Innova, 27 Dec – 1 Jan (6 days + driver nights + tolls)	₹5,600	₹6,000	≈ ₹33.5–36k ÷ 6 (more if Jalori is shut)
Manali → Delhi bus	₹1,000	₹1,800	HRTC ordinary vs Volvo
Delhi half-day on 2 Jan	₹300	₹400	
Train Delhi → Hyderabad (12724)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Airbnb/homestays: Mashobra 1N, Narkanda 2N, Jibhi 2N, Sethan 1N (NYE)	₹5,600	₹8,000	Entire homes / 3 rooms ÷ 6
Food (homestay dinners ₹300–400)	₹5,500	₹6,000	
Serolsar guide, GHNP entry, misc entries	₹400	₹500	
Winter gear rentals	₹800	₹1,000	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹22,515**	**₹29,915**	**Fits ₹25–30k on SL. One shared Innova is the single biggest saving versus 4 people (≈ ₹2,000 pp less).**

Bookings to do now

- Return 12724 (2 Jan) → 12723 (24 Dec) → **12311 Kalka Mail (25 Dec)** → **toy train (26 Dec)**, 6 on one PNR each.
- Sethan for 31 Dec first (fills fastest), then Jibhi, Narkanda, Mashobra.
- Fix the Innova (27 Dec–1 Jan) in writing: per-day rate, driver nights, tolls/parking, extra km if you take the Mandi route.
- Manali → Delhi bus for 1 Jan.

Plan B

- Jalori shut and you don't want the 8–9 h detour: reverse the loop (Delhi → overnight bus to Aut → Jibhi/Tirthan → Manali/Sethan → Kullu → Shimla–Narkanda → toy train down to Kalka → Kalka Mail to Delhi).
- Heavy snow at Narkanda: sleep in Thanedar (lower) and do Hatu on foot only in clear weather.
- Sethan road shut: sleep in Prini/Hamta village and walk up once it's cleared.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** each (Sikkim/Bhutan permits, J&K checks). **Nepal: passport or voter ID** (Aadhaar is generally not accepted).
- Power bank (cold halves battery life), offline maps, ₹5–8k cash each (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Group med kit: paracetamol, ORS, cold/cough tablets, band-aids, Vaseline, motion-sickness tablets (hill roads). Diamox only on a doctor's advice.
- Thermos for hot water, quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear, a 3-pin multi-plug for the Airbnb (one socket per room is common).
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K don't work in Kashmir. Carry at least 2 postpaid connections in the group (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Roads and snow change by the hour. Check state police traffic updates and ask your host each evening. Emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- No two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice. Taxis with chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book 30 Dec–1 Jan stays first (NYE rates 2–3×). Prefer flexible cancellation.
- Start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/railhead) by 1 Jan. NYE traffic and snow delay buses 3–8 h.

Sources checked

Reddit and direct page fetches (Airbnb, IRCTC, erail, ConfirmTkt) were blocked from this environment, so everything here comes from web-search results: Airbnb listing snippets, rail timetable aggregators, Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live prices could not be checked; use the checklists above to verify.

— Toy train & Kalka Mail: travelcoffee.in, Shimla Tourism, exploreindia, totaltraininfo, Cleartrip, RailMitra
— Jalori seasonal closure & Jibhi access: vargiskhan.com, travelcoffee.in, The Tribune (NH-305), Team-BHP 'Quiet flows Tirthan'
— Jibhi/Shoja/Tirthan winter: tourmyholiday 2025, travelcoffee 'Jibhi in December', Asianet Newsable
— Airbnb listings (ratings/reviews): airbnb.co.in Mashobra/Narkanda/Jibhi/Tirthan/Sethan/Prini pages via search (Nov 2026)
— Innova/Tempo rates: Rajputana Cabs, Triveni Cabs; HRTC Manali–Delhi fares: mytnstc table, EaseMyTrip